The Statesman

Though Honecker's enthusiasm for international politics overtook his interest in domestic issues, he still travelled extensively throughout the GDR. April found him at a series of anniversaries commemorating the end of the Second World War, including an appearance at Brandenburg-Görden prison, an occasion which marked the re-emergence Pyotr Abrasimov – the Russian envoy who had helped reinstate him in 1970 – as the new Soviet Ambassador.

In his address, Abrasimov praised the courage and strong convictions of KPD members who 'served as an example to those inside Germany in the battle against Nazism'. He praised the First Secretary and others like him who had been jailed for their 'heroic' opposition to fascism. In spite of such fervent words, however, a perceptible frost was settling over his relations with Honecker.

For the next eight years, Abrasimov would reside inside the elegant 334-room Soviet Embassy on Unter den Linden. His scowling face topped by a tinted mane became a fixture at high-level functions. Associates remembered he could be distant, short-tempered, icy and occasionally charming. And although there is no reliable evidence of him interfering in the day-to-day administration of East Germany, he was viewed – especially by foreign observers – as a 'little governor'. The West German magazine Der Spiegel sarcastically reported talks between Abrasimov and SED leadership were always referred to by Neues Deutschland as 'friendly and cordial'. However, over time, they became 'cordial and sincere,' which, according to diplomatic parlance, spelt differences of opinion.1

However, Abrasimov's diplomatic experience was genuinely useful in the spring of 1975 when he helped Honecker prepare to take his first step onto the world stage at the signing of the historic Helsinki Accords. Officially known as 'The Conference on Security and Cooperation in Europe', the process had begun some years earlier at the behest of Brezhnev with the